

Status Reporting

The goal of status reporting is to help project teams track progress, communicate effectively, and provide stakeholders with accurate and timely information. By the end of this reading, you will understand the need for periodic work performance reports, the significance of status reporting, and the attributes of an effective status report.

The Project Management Institute (PMI) emphasizes the importance of periodic work performance reports. These reports can take many forms, including status reports, memos, justifications, dashboards, and other formats. Periodic reports support better decision-making, help identify and raise issues, define required actions, and create awareness among team members and stakeholders.

Among these reports, status reports are one of the most frequently used. According to PMI, a status report provides the current status of a project, including progress since the last report and forecasts for cost and schedule performance. Typically, status reports are created weekly, although the frequency may vary depending on project needs. It is important to document the definition and frequency of status reporting in the communications management plan during project planning.

The project manager is responsible for establishing the format of status reports and the schedule for submission. In many organizations, a standard status report template is used across projects. For a status report to be effective, it should follow certain key attributes.

First, the report should focus on its audience. Content must be tailored to the readers' needs. For example, a weekly status report for the project team might include detailed line items, whereas a monthly report to senior management would highlight high-level milestones and key progress indicators.

Second, status reports should be concise. Ideally, they should fit on one page, with links or references provided for additional details as needed.

Third, the report should be formatted for readability. Essential information should be presented first, followed by secondary details. For example, milestones achieved, requirement changes, or high-level project summaries should be highlighted at the beginning.

Fourth, include factual and relevant data. Only add information that stakeholders require. Summarize development status rather than listing every line item, and use graphs or visuals to improve comprehension.

Fifth, use simple language that can be understood by varied audiences, including technical, non-technical, senior, and junior stakeholders. Avoid unnecessary technical jargon.